

SOP Manual — Bar, Pub and Microbrewery (India)

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Scope, roles and RACI legend

This manual covers bars, pubs, lounges, nightclubs and microbreweries in India, where state excise law governs nearly every step from purchase to pour. Food service in a bar follows the Standalone Restaurant manual; this manual adds what alcohol changes.

RACI: **R** does the work · **A** signs off (one per task) · **C** consulted before · **I** informed after.

Code	Role
OWN	Owner / Licensee (the person named on the excise licence)
GM	General Manager / Outlet Manager
BM	Bar Manager
HBT	Head Bartender
BT	Bartender
BB	Bar Back
FS	Floor Staff / Server
SEC	Security Head / Bouncers (PSARA-licensed agency)
EVM	Events / Entertainment Manager
BRW	Head Brewer (microbrewery)
ACC	Accountant / Excise Clerk
HC	Head Chef

Licences and legal rules

Alcohol is a state subject in India: each state's excise Act sets the licence type, opening hours, dry days, legal drinking age (18 to 25 depending on the state and the drink) and the registers you must keep. Treat the table below as a checklist, and record your state's exact rule beside each line.

Licence / rule	What it governs	Owner
Bar / on-premise licence (e.g. FL-3, permit room, FL-4A — names vary by state)	Selling liquor for consumption on the premises; licensed area marked on the site plan	OWN
Licence renewal	Usually yearly, often from 1 April; fees paid in advance	OWN, ACC
Occasional / event licence	Each special event, outdoor area or extended hours	EVM
Microbrewery licence	Brewing and selling beer on site; production limits, no bottling for outside sale in most states	OWN, BRW
Opening hours and dry days	Excise and police set closing times; dry days notified by the state (national holidays, elections, festivals)	GM
Legal drinking age	State-specific (18–25); applies to serving and to entry where the state requires	GM
Liquor taxes	Alcohol for human consumption is outside GST; state VAT or excise applies; food on the same bill carries 5% GST	ACC
Purchase source	Buy only from licensed wholesalers or the state corporation; carry the transport pass / permit	BM
FSSAI	Food licence covers the kitchen and also alcoholic beverages as food under the FSS Act	HC
Police / eating-house licence	Required in many cities for late hours and entertainment	OWN

Licence / rule	What it governs	Owner
Performance licence	Police or district permission for DJ, live band, dance floor in many states	EVM
Music licences	PPL / IPRS / Novex for recorded and live music	EVM
Noise	Noise Pollution (Regulation and Control) Rules 2000: no amplified sound in open areas 22:00–06:00 except as allowed	EVM, GM
Fire NOC	Higher occupancy and dance floors usually trigger stricter fire norms; maximum occupancy displayed	OWN
Service charge	Voluntary only; never by default (CCPA guidelines, upheld by Delhi HC on 28 Mar 2025) (Mondaq)	GM
Smoking	COTPA 2003: no smoking indoors except in a designated smoking area meeting the rules; no hookah where the state bans it; no sale of tobacco to under-18s	GM
Labour and security	Four Labour Codes (in force from 21 Nov 2025); bouncers only from PSARA-licensed agencies	OWN

The licensee is personally liable for excise breaches. The Bar Manager must keep a copy of every licence on the premises and produce it to an inspector on demand.

Bar operations (BR)

Every drink is poured to a measured recipe and rung into the POS before it leaves the bar.

BR-01 Bar opening.

1. Unlock the bar store with the manager present; issue stock against the par sheet.
2. Check glassware (no chips), ice machine clean and full, garnishes cut fresh and dated, juices within date, syrups labelled.
3. Check draught lines and gas (CO₂ or nitrogen) pressure; pour and discard the first pint per line.
4. Set up POS, jiggers, speed rail; count and sign the opening bottle tally.

BR-02 Standard pours.

Drink	Standard measure
Spirits (single / large)	30 ml / 60 ml
Wine (glass)	150 ml (125 ml in some menus; state it on the menu)
Draught beer	300 ml / 500 ml, marked glass
Cocktails	Per recipe card

Use jiggers or calibrated pourers; no free pouring. Menus state measures in ml.

BR-03 Cocktail recipe cards. Each cocktail has a card with ingredients in ml, method, glass, garnish, photo, cost and allergens (dairy, egg white, nuts); new cocktails approved by BM after costing.

BR-04 Order to serve. Order punched in the POS first; bartender makes only from the printed or screen ticket; drinks delivered within 5 minutes; complimentary drinks need a manager's code.

BR-05 Glassware and ice hygiene. Glass washer at the supplier's rinse temperature; glasses air-dried, never towel-polished with a dirty cloth; ice scooped, never with a glass; broken glass in the ice well → melt and refill the whole well.

BR-06 Draught line cleaning. Clean lines every 7–14 days with line cleaner; log date and person; sample taste check after cleaning.

BR-07 Bar closing. Last order at the licensed time; final pours rung in; bottles counted (by weight or tenths) and recorded; open stock locked; speed rail bottles capped; drains and ice well cleaned; register updated.

RACI — Bar operations

Activity	GM	BM	HBT	BT	BB	FS
Bar opening and issue	I	A	R	R	R	–
Standard pours	I	A	R	R	–	–
Cocktail recipes and costing	C	A	R	C	–	–
Order to serve	I	A	R	R	C	R
Glass and ice hygiene	–	A	R	R	R	–
Draught line cleaning	–	A	R	R	R	–
Bar closing count	I	A	R	R	R	–

Responsible service of alcohol (RS)

Staff must refuse alcohol to anyone under the state's legal age or visibly intoxicated, and the manager must back that refusal every time.

RS-01 Age check.

1. Ask for government photo ID from anyone who looks under 30, at the door and at the bar.
2. Accept Aadhaar (masked copy or the physical card), passport, driving licence, voter ID; reject damaged or photocopied IDs.
3. Refuse politely; never serve an adult who is buying for a minor in the group.
4. Minors accompanied by adults may be allowed only where the state permits and only in non-bar seating; they are never served alcohol.

RS-02 Watching for intoxication. Staff look for slurred speech, loss of balance, loud or aggressive behaviour, spilling drinks, falling asleep. Track drinks per guest on the POS table tab; the BM reviews tables above 6 standard drinks.

RS-03 Refusing service. Approach privately; use "we", not "you"; offer water, food and a seat; stop service for the rest of the visit; inform the manager and security; log the refusal with time and description.

RS-04 Getting guests home safely. Offer a cab or call a contact; never let a visibly intoxicated guest drive (keep a valet key policy where valet exists); note the plate number and inform the manager if a guest insists.

RS-05 Promotions. No "unlimited drinks" or drinking games; happy hours only within state rules; no promotions aimed at students; non-alcoholic options on every menu.

RS-06 Drink spiking prevention. Watch for unattended drinks; cover-the-glass coasters available; train staff to spot spiking and to call medical help; treat any report as an emergency and call 112.

RS-07 Staff drinking. No alcohol on duty; tasting only under the BM for training, spat out or measured; a staff member unfit for work is sent home and logged.

RACI — Responsible service

Activity	GM	BM	BT	FS	SEC
ID checks	A	R	R	R	R
Monitoring drink count	I	A	R	R	C
Refusing service	C	A	R	R	R
Safe-transport help	I	A	R	R	R

Activity	GM	BM	BT	FS	SEC
Promotions approval	A	R	C	–	–
Spiking response	A	R	R	R	R
Refusal and incident log	I	A	R	R	R

Liquor stock control and excise registers (LC)

The excise register, the POS and the physical stock must agree every night; a gap is both a cost leak and a licence risk.

LC-01 Purchase. Order only from licensed suppliers or the state corporation; check the transport permit and the hologram or track-and-trace label on every bottle; record the purchase in the excise register the same day.

LC-02 Bond store. Liquor stored in a locked room with two keys (BM and GM); stock arranged by brand; only full, sealed bottles in the store.

LC-03 Issues to bar. Requisition by the HBT; empty-for-full exchange for spirits; issue logged against bottle count.

LC-04 Daily sale register. Record daily sales by brand and size in the state's prescribed format (manual register or online excise portal); keep pages numbered, no blank lines or erasures.

LC-05 Nightly reconciliation. Opening stock + issues – closing stock = consumption; compare with POS sales in ml; variance above 2% per brand investigated the next day.

LC-06 Empty bottles. Break, deface or return empties per state rules to prevent refilling; log the count.

LC-07 Monthly count and cost. Full count with ACC; beverage cost % by category (spirits, beer, wine, cocktails); slow movers flagged for promotion or return.

LC-08 Excise inspection. Produce licence, purchase invoices, transport passes, registers and stock; manager stays with the inspector; sign the inspection note only after reading.

RACI — Liquor control

Activity	OWN	GM	BM	HBT	ACC
Purchase from licensed source	I	A	R	–	C
Bond store custody	I	A	R	–	–
Issues to bar	–	I	A	R	–
Excise register entries	I	C	A	R	R

Activity	OWN	GM	BM	HBT	ACC
Nightly reconciliation	-	I	A	R	C
Empty bottle disposal	-	I	A	R	-
Monthly count and cost	I	C	R	-	A
Excise inspection	I	A	R	-	R

Door, security and crowd management (DS)

The venue never exceeds the occupancy on its fire NOC, and security staff de-escalate first and use force only as a last resort to protect people.

DS-01 Door policy. Written entry policy (age, dress code if any, couples or stag rules) displayed at the door and applied to everyone equally; no refusal on caste, religion, gender, disability or region; refusals logged.

DS-02 Occupancy count. Clicker count in and out at every entrance; the door stops entry at 95% of licensed capacity; the count is radioed to the GM every 30 minutes on busy nights.

DS-03 Searches. Bag and frisk checks by same-gender staff, with consent, in view of CCTV; no weapons, drugs or outside alcohol; found drugs handed to police, never kept.

DS-04 Bouncer conduct. PSARA agency staff with police verification; uniform and ID; conflict-avoidance training; no alcohol on duty; body-worn cameras where used, with notice to guests.

DS-05 Fights and ejection. Separate the parties; ask them to leave; escort out with two staff; call police (112) if anyone is hurt or threatened; first aid; write the incident report and save CCTV.

DS-06 Women's safety. Female security staff on every busy shift; "Ask for help" signage in washrooms with a code word; staff walk a guest to a cab if asked; harassment complaints taken seriously and acted on immediately.

DS-07 Drugs. Zero tolerance under the NDPS Act; any sale or use leads to ejection and police report; staff found involved are suspended and reported.

DS-08 Evacuation. Exits marked, lit and unlocked during trading; music cut and house lights up on alarm; staff guide guests to exits; assembly point headcount of staff.

RACI — Door and security

Activity	OWN	GM	SEC	BM	FS
Door policy	A	R	R	-	-
Occupancy control	I	A	R	-	-
Searches	-	A	R	-	-
Bouncer agency compliance	A	R	R	-	-
Fights and ejection	I	A	R	C	C
Women's safety measures	I	A	R	R	R
Drug incidents	I	A	R	C	C
Evacuation	I	A	R	R	R

Events, DJ and live music (EV)

No event runs without its permissions in hand at least 48 hours before, and sound levels stay inside the licence and the noise rules.

EV-01 Event planning. Event brief 14 days ahead: concept, expected footfall, ticketing, artists, technical rider, F&B plan, security plan, budget; approved by GM.

EV-02 Permissions. Occasional liquor licence or extension where needed; police performance permission; music licences; ticketed events may need entertainment tax or GST on tickets per state rules; copies filed.

EV-03 Artist contracts. Fee, set times, rider, cancellation, TDS, content rules (no obscenity or hate speech); artist arrival and sound-check times.

EV-04 Sound. Sound engineer sets limiter; decibel meter checked hourly; outdoor amplified sound stops by 22:00 unless permitted.

EV-05 Ticketing and guest list. Ticket scanning at the door; guest list closed 30 minutes before start; capacity rules in DS-02 apply.

EV-06 Post-event. Reconcile tickets, door count and bar sales; artist payment; debrief notes; damage and incident review.

RACI — Events

Activity	OWN	GM	EVM	BM	SEC	ACC
Event brief and budget	C	A	R	C	C	C
Permissions	I	A	R	-	-	C

Activity	OWN	GM	EVM	BM	SEC	ACC
Artist contracts	C	A	R	–	–	C
Sound limits	–	A	R	–	–	–
Ticketing and door	–	A	R	–	R	–
Post-event reconciliation	I	A	R	R	C	R

Microbrewery production (MB)

A microbrewery brews only within its licensed capacity, records every batch in the excise production register, and keeps the brewhouse to the same hygiene standard as a kitchen.

MB-01 Raw materials. Malt, hops, yeast and adjuncts from approved suppliers; stored dry, cool, pest-proof; FEFO; batch numbers recorded.

MB-02 Brewing. Recipe sheet per beer; mash, boil and fermentation temperatures and times recorded; original and final gravity measured and logged; batch volume entered in the excise register.

MB-03 Cleaning (CIP). Clean-in-place after every brew: caustic wash, rinse, acid wash, rinse, sanitise; concentration and temperature logged; PPE for chemicals.

MB-04 Fermentation and conditioning. Tank labels with beer, batch, brew date, status; daily gravity and temperature checks; pressure relief valves checked.

MB-05 Quality. Taste panel before release; ABV estimated from gravity and declared on the menu; batches failing standard dumped and recorded in the register.

MB-06 Safety. CO₂ monitors in cellar and brewhouse; confined-space permit for tank entry; hot liquor and steam lines guarded; boilers and pressure vessels inspected per state rules.

MB-07 Spent grain and waste water. Spent grain to approved feed or compost partners; effluent treated per the SPCB consent.

RACI — Microbrewery

Activity	OWN	GM	BRW	BM	ACC
Raw materials	I	C	A/R	–	C
Brewing and batch log	–	I	A/R	–	C
Excise production register	I	C	R	–	A
CIP cleaning	–	–	A/R	–	–
Quality release	–	C	A	R	–

Activity	OWN	GM	BRW	BM	ACC
Brewhouse safety	I	C	A/R	–	–
Waste and effluent	I	A	R	–	–

Food, cash, people and compliance calendar

Kitchen, billing, HR and cleaning follow the Standalone Restaurant manual; the points below are where a bar differs.

- **Billing:** liquor and food are taxed differently. Food carries 5% GST, and alcohol carries state VAT. Show them as separate tax lines, or as separate bills where the state requires it. Service contribution is voluntary only.
- **Cash control:** bar tabs held on a card pre-authorisation or ID; no open tabs without a manager's approval; walkouts logged.
- **Staff:** bartenders trained in responsible service before their first shift; night-shift transport; the OSH Code and state rules on women working late (consent and safety measures).
- **Food safety:** bar garnishes, ice and juices count as food under FSSAI; the Food Safety Supervisor's logs cover the bar.

Frequency	Task	Owner
Nightly	Stock reconciliation, excise daily register, occupancy log, incident log	BM, SEC
Weekly	Draught line clean (7–14 days), high-value stock count	BM
Monthly	Full stock count, beverage cost review, extinguisher check, pest control	ACC, GM
Before each event	Permissions, artist contract, security plan	EVM
Each brew	Batch and excise production entries, CIP log	BRW
Annually	Excise licence renewal (often 1 April), fire NOC, police/performance licence, music licences, FSSAI, SOP review	OWN
Each notified dry day	No sale; bar store sealed; staff briefed the day before	GM

Sources

- [CCPA service charge guidelines upheld by Delhi HC](#)
- [FSSAI FoSTaC](#)
- [Labour Codes implementation](#)

Excise rules differ sharply by state; confirm every licence name, hour and register format with your state excise department. This is operational guidance, not legal advice.